

The Series of the Knights of Columbus in the United States and Mexico During the Early
Twentieth Century

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During the early twentieth century, there were major internal and external conflicts that impacted world history. Similarly to how both the First and Second World Wars devastated the population and immigration of how people used to live before, several conflicts within a nation, like the Soviet Union, damage the political and social sphere that would end up persecuting a specific ethnic or religious group. Mexico would be no exception to the internal conflict. After the Mexican Revolution, Venustiano Carranza, one of the Mexican revolutionist leaders, established the Constitution of 1917, forming a modern government under the United Mexican States that would offer democracy to all Mexican citizens. However, the Constitution included anticlerical laws that would sour the relationship between the Church and State, all the way until both sides ended up in military conflict during the presidency of Plutarco Elias Calles in the *Cristero War* between 1926 to 1929. Unfortunately, despite the impact between the Church and State throughout the nation, the education system teaches little to no information regarding the *Cristero War*, which is an important subject to learn more about since religion plays a major part of Mexican history. In order to understand the conflict of the *Cristero War* than to present the historical evidence of the Knights of Columbus, a Catholic men's fraternity organization that was founded in New Haven, Connecticut, United States, ended up participating in supporting Mexican Catholics on the Mexican anticlerical laws' affair. Throughout the conflict, the Knights of Columbus played a role in allying together with other Catholic laity organizations, fighting alongside *Cristeros*, and protesting the Mexican government from the American side of the border, while supporting Mexican immigrant Catholics through charity in the United States.

On the Mexican side of the border, the Knights of Columbus would work together with other Catholic laity organizations that were dedicated to rallying and protesting the Mexican anticlerical laws before the *Cristero War*. Indeed, the Knights of Columbus were first known as the *Consejo de Guadalupe*, which was first established by American and Irish Catholics living in

Mexico City on November 5th, 1905, and would work together with other existing Catholic laity organizations to form the Mexican Catholic Youth Association (A.C.J.M.) in 1913 to promote the religious rights for all Mexicans under the influence of the Mexican government through the revolution.¹ This was an important case for the Knights to get involved with the A.C.J.M., since President Alvaro Obregon, before the *Cristero War*, was already preventing the Roman Catholic Church from constructing a monument. The monument was dedicated to the Sacred Heart of Jesus, at the center of the nation, that is the *Cerro de Cubilete* located in the state of Guanajuato. According to President Obregon, the main reason why he decided to stop the construction was that the priest who was planning out the monument was a foreign clergy, which he did not have the right to construct the monument of the Sacred Heart of Jesus for pilgrimage purposes, since this action would break the Article 33 of the Constitution of 1917.²

While Obregon's action didn't lead to much of a protest, the Knights of Columbus, alongside other Catholic laity organizations, would protest together with Archbishop Dr. Jose Mora y del Rio against President Plutarco Elias Calles, who ran for office from 1924 to 1928 for working with Fr. Joaquin Perez y Budar to establish the *Mexican Catholic Church*, a separated see that the division is not of religious purposes but of political ideals to destroy the Roman Catholic unity.³ Knowing this, this action would lead the Knights of Columbus to play an important role to support the Catholic Church in Mexico through protest, yet this wouldn't be enough for the upcoming conflict during the *Cristero War*.

¹ Alicia Olivera Sedano, *Aspecto Del Conflicto Religioso de 1926 a 1929: Sus Antecedentes y Consecuencias* (Mexico City: Instituto Nacional de Antropologia e Historia, 1966), 67 – 69.

² Sedano, *Aspecto Del Conflicto Religioso de 1926 a 1929*, 70 – 71.

³ Sedano, *Aspecto Del Conflicto Religioso de 1926 a 1929*, 81 – 83.

Afterward, President Calles' enactment of the Penal Code, also known as *Calles' Law*, it would spark the protest of the Roman Catholic Church, which many Catholics revolted against the Mexican federal government, including the Knights of Columbus. Furthermore, the establishment of the Penal Code in July 1926, by President Calles, would strictly enforce several articles of the Constitution of 1917 that would prevent both the clergies and the laity of the Roman Catholic Church from freely practicing their religious beliefs in both political and social sphere. One of those strict preventions would involve that the clergy could not practice their faith in public, could not own public schools, nor promote religious vocations to other people, while Catholic laity could not promote their faith to anyone, not even teach their faith to their children.⁴ While some of these laws do not seem as strict, President Calles declared in the Penal Code that mass celebration was to be supervised by the federal soldiers and prevented any political figures may associate with the Catholic Church, while declaring that all Catholic temples are to become government property, which takes away the right of clergies, regardless of whether they're Mexican citizens, to not own their private property.⁵ According to President Calles, if these laws were to be broken, then the punishment would be either \$500 MN pesos fine, imprisonment of days to months, or worst-case scenario, execution, depending on how severe the law was broken. This in turn led the bishops of the Roman Catholic Church to protest President Calles by shutting down every sacrament service, which is essential for the life of Catholic laity to practice their faith, leading some to revolt, including some local Knights of Columbus, to arm against the Mexican government on August 3, 1926.

⁴ Eduardo Lopez Gallardo, *Diario Oficial: Organo del Gobierno Constitucional de los Estados Unidos Mexicanos* (Mexico City: Office Journal of the Federation, 1926). 1 – 2.

⁵ Gallardo, *Diario Oficial*, 3 - 4.

While there were several local Knights of Columbus who fought against the federal soldiers, there were several members who supported the Roman Catholic Church in Mexico without using bloody violence. Moreover, Pope Pius XI wrote an encyclical letter, also known as *Iniquis Afflictisque*, to the Church of Mexico, that is to all Catholics who were suffering from the *Cristero War* at the hands of the Mexican federal government, on November 18th, 1926. In the encyclical, Pious XI recognized the importance of the Knights of Columbus, blessing them for promoting the National Solidarity of Fathers of Families and the Federation for the Defense of Religious Liberty⁶. Within the National Solidarity of Fathers of Families, the Knights of Columbus promoted to protection of the rights of parents to teach their children about the Catholic faith during the *Cristero War*. In the case of the program of the Federation for the Defense of Religious Liberty, the Knights of Columbus were part of the organization to organize and instruct other Catholics to unite and defend against the federal soldiers for the right to protect their religious liberty from the Mexican government. Indeed, these programs were promoted by the Knights of Columbus to support Mexican Catholics during the *Cristero War*, which Pope Pius XI fully recognized their works and efforts against the Mexican authority.

Not surprisingly, the role of the Knights of Columbus during the *Cristero War* would turn them into an enemy target by the Mexican federal government, viewing them as traitors to the sovereignty and the revolutionary ideals of Mexico. Eight days after Pope Pius XI publicized his encyclical *Iniquis Afflictisque*, Benito Juarez Ochoa, President of the Chamber of Deputies of Congress of the United Mexican States, reunite all 193 deputies at the chamber to discuss several topics regarding the issue that the nation was going through. Additionally, Secretary Cerisola shared his speech criticizing the clergies of the Roman Catholic Church for attempting to negotiate to bend the Constitutional laws, while viewing both the Church and the Knights of

⁶ Pius XI, *Iniquis Afflictisque* (Vatican City: Vatican Publishing House, 1926).

Columbus as traitors of the Mexican sovereignty.⁷ Not only did he view the Knights of Columbus as traitors for supporting the Roman Catholic Church by fighting alongside the *Cristeros*, Secretary Cerisola also viewed the Knights of Columbus as a potential threat to the Mexican government since he highly criticized the Supreme Council of the United States reuniting all delegates at a conference in Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, shortly after the *Cristero War* began. Which Secretary Cerisola claimed that the Supreme Council and the rest of the Knights of Columbus planned to promote anti-Mexican anticlerical laws and plan to persuade the American government to unrecognize the Mexican government.⁸ From Secretary Cerisola's point of view, the issue was not about a decision to overthrow a religious institution from Mexico, but instead, overthrow a potential political force, which the Roman Catholic Church had been in power during Spanish colonialism, viewing it more of a foreign institution. And now that the Roman Catholic Church was persecuted during the *Cristero War*, during which the clergies did seek the Knights of Columbus' help, especially from the United States, this gave more excuses to the deputies, especially Secretary Cerisola, to view the Church as only seeking foreign support, which the Mexican government was intolerant.

On the American side of the border, James A. Flaherty, Supreme Council of the Knights of Columbus, formed a convention in Philadelphia, Pennsylvania to reunite with other delegates and discuss the conflict between the Church and State in Mexico in August 1926. Indeed, Flaherty, together with other delegates of the Knights of Columbus, established the Million Dollar Fund, a donation that would support the Mexican Knights of Columbus by funding a publicity campaign that would alert the American public about Mexico's persecution of the

⁷ Benito Juarez Ochoa, *Diario de los Debates de la Camara de Diputados del Congreso de los Estados Unidos Mexicanos* (Mexico City: Chamber of Deputies of Congress, 1926).

⁸ Ochoa, *Diario de los Debates*.

Catholic Church.⁹ Besides, the Knights of Columbus were hoping to persuade the American government, through publicity, to withdraw their recognition of the Mexican government by comparing it to a new form of the Bolshevik movement. After all, the idea of the spread of the Soviet Union into the southern borders of the United States seemed like a promising idea for the Knights of Columbus to grab the attention of the American government to interfere in the crisis between the Church and State in Mexico.¹⁰ Nonetheless, this would cause turmoil that both the Coolidge and Hoover administrations to not meddle with Mexican affairs since the action to overthrow the government that the United States recognized was considered politically illegal.

Because of this case, the Mexican government ordered the Confidential Department to investigate all Mexican citizens to capture and prevent the Knights of Columbus from achieving their goal that was established in the convention of Philadelphia. Moreover, once discovered which individual is a member of the Knights of Columbus, the Confidential Department would dismiss them from their careers, surveil them, detain them, or sometimes imprison them.¹¹ While it was rare, there were occasions when the Confidential Department would even execute any members of the Knights of Columbus, like the example of eight priests who were all members of the Knights. This would lead for the Knights of Columbus to seek help from the American Knights of Columbus in any form to combat against the Mexican government.

⁹ Julia G. Young, *Knights and Caballeros: Cross-Border Catholic Activism During Mexico's Cristero War* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2017), 256 – 57.

¹⁰ Young, *Knights and Caballeros*, 257.

¹¹ Young, *Knights and Caballeros*, 255.

After the end of the *Cristero War*, under *Modus Vivendi*, the Mexican government changed its tactics of attacking the Roman Catholic Church through politics and education, both the Knights of Columbus and the federal government would compete against each other through the formation of the political parties during the early 20th century. Furthermore, Calles, despite completing his office in 1928, continued to work behind the scenes by influencing other presidents to continue establishing anticlerical laws, creating a period known as the *Maximato*, where Calles became the “Maximum Leader.” Also, Calles would make the *Cry of Guadalajara*, declaring to “control the minds of children,” through education to prevent the Church from influencing over the Mexican social sphere.¹² As a result, the Knights would ally with other Catholic laity organizations to combat politically against the Mexican government, forming the *Catholic Action* movement. This would lead the *Action Catholic* to contribute to the rise of a Mexican conservative political party, known as PAN, which is made to rival Calles’ political party National Revolutionary Party, also known as PNR, which is modern-day PRI.¹³ Thus, both the PRI and PAN would compete against each other within the political sphere of Mexico in the late 1930s.

Whereas the Knights of Columbus, in the United States, would protest the American government from not participating to end the conflict between the Church and State in Mexico, which in turn led them to change tactics and support financially the Mexican Catholic immigrants. Additionally, Archbishop Michael Joseph Curley of the Dioceses of Baltimore

¹² Roberto Blancarte, *Historia de la Iglesia Catolica en Mexico* (Zinacantepec, State of Mexico: El Colegio Mexiquense S.A., 1992), 32 - 41.

¹³ Young, *Knights and Caballeros*, 270.

would influence the Knights of Columbus from starting to protest the Mexican government during the 1930s, while he verbally attacked the American government for not responding to the Mexican affair.¹⁴ At the same time, the Supreme Knight, Martin H. Carmody, would confer with Secretary Hull in Washington, where he demanded a blunt warning against Mexico that the diplomatic relations would end if the persecution did not stop. Moreover, Carmody would protest Ambassador Josephus Daniel for quoting a similar speech from Calles on “controlling the mind of children,” despite not knowing the context of the quote.¹⁵ This in turn would lead the American government to not follow along on the demands of the Knights of Columbus, which caused the failure of the primary goal of to support Mexican Catholics from the anticlerical laws of Mexico.

By contrast, the Mexican government would justify its actions of targeting the Knights of Columbus, as well as implementing anticlerical laws against the Roman Catholic Church, as a response to defend the nation’s sovereignty from foreign institutions. Furthermore, the Mexican government does not have any interest in whether if its citizens are considered Christians or not, but they do not consider the Roman Catholic Church, a religious institution, as a true Christian denomination since they view it that it follows superstitious practices, which its only goal is to exploit its followers by establishing a type of medieval government within an independent state of Mexico.¹⁶ Indeed, the Mexican government would view this action as a threat for the future

¹⁴ Thomas W. Spalding, *The Premier: A History of the Archdiocese of Baltimore, 1789 – 1989* (Baltimore: The Johns Hopkins University Press, 1989), 349 – 51.

¹⁵ Edmund David Cronon, *American Catholics and Mexican Anticlericalism, 1933 – 1936* (Oxford, United Kingdom: Oxford University Press, 1958), 201 – 30.

¹⁶ Alfonso Toro, *La Iglesia y el Estado en Mexico* (Mexico City: Secretariat of the Interior, 1927), 361 - 62.

and sovereignty of the United Mexican States, which it fought both independence and revolution to become free from any foreign influence from establishing any type of monarchy identical from Europe. In this sense, the federal government's only attempt to install anticlerical laws was to protect the rights and liberties of all Mexican citizens from any form of exploitation by any form of foreign institutions, regardless of whether if the institution is religious or not.

However, the Knights of Columbus, together with the *Cristeros* and the Mexican devout Catholic population, responded to the anticlerical laws through protest and war to keep their religious freedom, which was contrary to what the Mexican government expected from their citizens. In the case of the Knights of Columbus, they were established in Mexico City as the *Order of Guadalupe* in 1905, which by 1923, it grew by 45 Mexican Council and 5,102 across the country.¹⁷ Evidence illustrates that the Catholic population in Mexico was willing to join in with the Knights of Columbus by their free will of becoming a member of a Catholic fraternity group of men. Besides, the Knights of Columbus would ally together with other Catholic laity organizations to defend the religious freedom from the anticlerical laws that the Mexican government established. Also, by the start of the Mexican Revolution in 1910, around 99.5% of the whole Mexican population declared to be part of the One, Holy, Roman, Catholic, Apostolic Church.¹⁸ As a result, the Mexican government would install anticlerical laws within the Constitution of 1917, not because the Mexican people begged the government to remove and eliminate the Roman Catholic Church from Mexico by choice. Instead, they would establish their laws according to their point of view on how they thought what was good for the nation.

¹⁷ Young, *Knights and Caballeros*, 251.

¹⁸ Enríques Canudas Sandoval, *El Conflicto Iglesia-Estado Durante la Revolución Mexicana* (Mexico City: Virtual Judicial Library of UNAM, 2012), 143

Therefore, it would be more of a biased form of governing the nation that the federal government, including former president Calles, would run over the nation.

In the end, the Knights of Columbus played a role in allying together with other Catholic laity organizations, fighting alongside *Cristeros*, and protesting the Mexican government from the American side of the border, while supporting Mexican immigrant Catholics through charity in the United States. The participation of the Knights of Columbus on both sides of the border during the early twentieth century is essential to understanding how the conflict developed over time and how this event impacted the political and social sphere until the present day.

Unfortunately, not many people know much about the historical events of the *Cristero War* since it teaches little to no information about the war, at least within the community college course level of Mexican history. To ignore the religious conflict against the Mexican government within history is to disregard most of Mexican history, for religion in Mexico is a central core of what forms the identity of the Mexicans, regardless of whether one is a member of the Roman Catholic Church or not. In the end, it is crucial to understand its history more now than before, since this historical event was focused on by both the United States and Mexico's governments, even if their goal was not successful in the process.

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